MARKET RESEARCH REPORT · OCTOBER 2026

Prepared for Zain Sudan Business

Zain Sudan Business: Sudan B2B Market Opportunity

What Zain can offer Sudan's businesses and institutions, who to serve first, why it will work, and why Zain is the right operator to lead. Organised sector by sector.

Where Sudan's business connects.

هنا تتواصل أعمال السودان

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Confidential

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A market reading for Zain Sudan Business leadership, built from public sources accessed up to 26 October 2026.

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How to read the evidence markers

Every material fact carries a marker and a numbered source (listed in the appendix with URLs). VERIFIED primary or official source read directly. REPORTED credible secondary or news source. INFERENCE Franco Pinto's reasoning from cited facts. UNKNOWN no public figure found; nothing has been estimated in its place. Where sources disagree (for example on Zain's results or the exchange rate), each figure is shown with its own source and date rather than merged.

01 · AT A GLANCE

Executive summary

The opportunity in one page: what is changing, who to serve, and what Zain should lead with.

12.4M
Zain Sudan customers, Q1 2026, up 13% year on year
Zain Group Q1 2026 release [7] VERIFIED

US$157M
Zain Sudan Q1 2026 revenue, +34% YoY; data is 37% of revenue
Zain Group Q1 2026 release [7] VERIFIED

Nov 2026
End of the Starlink grace period for humanitarian users; Thuraya already ended 1 Feb 2026
Logistics Cluster, ETC [36,33] VERIFIED

14%
Share of the US$2.87bn 2026 humanitarian plan that is funded; 33.7M people in need
OCHA HNRP 2026 [26] VERIFIED

~48%
Fall of the Sudanese pound, Dec 2025 to Jul 2026; inflation 51.3% y/y at end-June 2026
World Bank MPO Oct 2026 [20] VERIFIED

Jan 2026
Government formally returned to Khartoum; ministries, banks and UN agencies are re-establishing there
Sudan Tribune, SUNA [48] VERIFIED

Five findings

1. **The addressable market is the SAF-held east, north and centre, now including Khartoum again.** Port Sudan, Kassala, Gedaref, Atbara, Dongola, Kosti, Damazine and Khartoum have working networks; Darfur and most of Kordofan do not and are out of scope [35,36] VERIFIED.
2. **Alternatives to licensed operators are being squeezed.** Starlink is unlicensed and its humanitarian grace period ends in November 2026, Thuraya was terminated in February, and the humanitarian telecom cluster has no 2026 funding and has moved to cost sharing [36,33] VERIFIED. Organisations now have to buy their own licensed connectivity INFERENCE.
3. **Zain already has most of what the market needs**, from APN and Bulk SMS to IoT, Fleet, Cloud and the Bede wallet with a corporate disbursement product [1,12] VERIFIED. It has also just won reference deals with the Ministry of Finance (Eisali SMS, Oct 2026) and Sudan Customs (IoT cargo, Jan 2026) [13,14] VERIFIED.
4. **The gaps are fixed fibre, satellite, managed security and data-centre services**, where Sudani markets offers and Zain lists none [17,1] VERIFIED. These can be closed through partners rather than new network build INFERENCE.
5. **The main constraints are commercial, not demand:** a collapsing currency with several exchange rates, outages and state-ordered shutdowns, and targeted sanctions that require counterparty screening [23,40,64] VERIFIED.

Top recommendation

Lead with **NGOs/UN and banks** in the next 90 days, using two ready-to-sell bundles built on existing Zain products: **Connected Aid** (Bede Corporate disbursement, beneficiary SMS/IVR, staff SIM pools, APN and data-card failover) timed against the November 2026 Starlink deadline, and **Transaction Messaging & Terminal Connectivity** (SMPP OTP and dual-path APN for POS and ATMs) as banks reconnect to the restored national payment switch. Follow with logistics, SMEs and a Zain-led government track that replicates the Eisali model. Franco Pinto supplies the integration, reconciliation and resilience layer that turns Zain products into working solutions.

PRIORITY TIER	SECTORS	WHEN
1. Move now	NGOs / UN / humanitarian; Banking & fintech	0 to 90 days
2. Build next	Logistics & ports; Retail & SMEs; Government (Zain-led)	3 to 6 months
3. Programme-led	Health; Agriculture & exports (mostly through NGO and donor programmes)	6 to 12 months
4. Gated or later	Mining (Zain-led due diligence only); Education; Oil & energy; Construction; Hospitality	12 months and as conditions allow

02 · THE LAY OF THE LAND

Market context

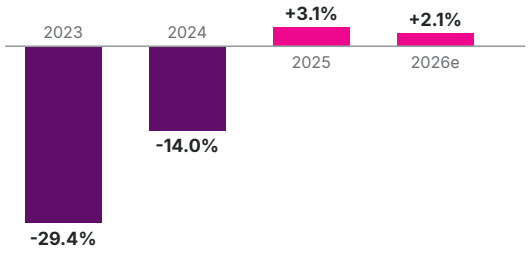
A divided economy that is partly recovering, with demand concentrated where networks, banks and government are working again.

A war economy, partly recovering

Sudan's economy contracted by almost half over 2023 and 2024 and has returned to modest growth. The World Bank estimates real GDP fell 29.4% in 2023 and 14.0% in 2024, grew 3.1% in 2025 and will grow about 2.1% in 2026 [20] VERIFIED. The IMF is more optimistic, projecting 7.0% growth in 2026 with 41.3% inflation [21] VERIFIED. Both views agree on the direction: activity is restarting in the areas the government controls.

The recovery sits on a fragile base. Extreme poverty is estimated at 59.7% in 2026, government revenue at only 4.0% of GDP [20] VERIFIED, and 33.7 million people need humanitarian assistance [26] VERIFIED. Official exports in 2025 were US$2.64bn, of which gold was US$1.536bn [25] VERIFIED.

REAL GDP GROWTH, WORLD BANK



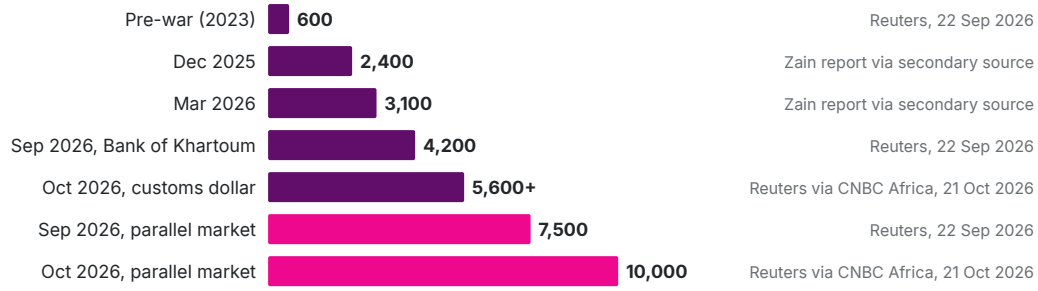
Source: World Bank Sudan MPO, Oct 2026 [20]. 2026 is an estimate. IMF projects +7.0% for 2026 [21].

INDICATOR	VALUE	DATE	EVIDENCE
Population	51.7 million	2026	VERIFIED [21,26]
Inflation (CPI)	51.3% y/y at end-June 2026; World Bank 2026 estimate 77.7%; IMF 41.3%	2026	VERIFIED [20,21]
Internet users	14.9 million (28.7% penetration)	Oct 2025	REPORTED [32]
Displacement	9.3M internally displaced; 4.4M refugees abroad; more than 2.2M returned to Khartoum and Aj Jazirah	Data as of 30 Oct 2025	VERIFIED [26]
Humanitarian plan	US$2.87bn requirement, 14% funded; 170+ organisations	2026	VERIFIED [26]
Rural grid access	Fell from 52% to 5% of rural households	2025	VERIFIED [29]

The currency: several rates, all moving one way

There is no single exchange rate to plan around. The figures below come from different sources and measure different rates, so they are shown side by side rather than combined. The direction is clear: the pound has lost most of its value since the war began, and the central bank no longer updates its official rate [23] VERIFIED. In August 2026 the central bank reportedly allowed banks and exchange bureaus to change posted rates at any time [71] REPORTED.

REPORTED SDG PER US DOLLAR, BY SOURCE AND DATE (NOT A SINGLE SERIES)



Sources: Reuters 22 Sep 2026 [23]; Reuters via CNBC Africa 21 Oct 2026 [24]; Zain report via secondary summary [11]. The World Bank separately reports a ~48% depreciation from Dec 2025 to Jul 2026 [20]. Highlighted bars are parallel-market rates.

> **What this means for B2B offers**
>
> Any contract priced in Sudanese pounds loses value within months. Enterprise offers should be designed with indexed or hard-currency reference pricing where the rules allow it, short billing cycles and prepayment for setup work. The applicable central bank rules on hard-currency pricing are not confirmed in public sources UNKNOWN.

Where Zain can sell: the addressable map

The government formally returned to Khartoum on 11 January 2026 [48] VERIFIED. Some ministries still work partly from Port Sudan or from hosted premises, and staff were ordered to report to Khartoum by the end of October 2026 [49] REPORTED. Port Sudan remains the main trade gateway and humanitarian hub [25,36] VERIFIED. In May 2026 the RSF-aligned "Ta'sis" authority set up a parallel central bank in Nyala [22] REPORTED, which splits the payments system as well as the territory.

	SAF-HELD: EAST, NORTH, CENTRE AND KHARTOUM	RSF-HELD: MOST OF DARFUR, PARTS OF KORDOFAN
Mobile networks	Partial to good but congested and costly. Restoration mainly in Port Sudan, Kassala, Khartoum and Atbara [35] VERIFIED; also Gedaref, Damazine and Kosti [36] VERIFIED. Zain reports more than 90% of its network active "in safe areas" (Q1 2026) [11] REPORTED.	Minimal or none: fibre cuts, destroyed towers and shutdowns ordered by both sides [33,35] VERIFIED.
Satellite	Starlink banned since 31 Jan 2024; thousands of terminals confiscated, enforcement uneven [39] REPORTED.	Smuggled Starlink is the main access, about US$2,500 per kit plus an RSF "tax"; the RSF itself has confiscated kits at times [39,55,56] REPORTED.
Banking	National payment switch restored Aug 2026; branches reopening in Khartoum and Omdurman [52] REPORTED.	Bankak restricted; parallel central bank; cash shortages; transfer fees of 23 to 25% reported in South Darfur mines [22,54] REPORTED.
Business activity	Trade through Port Sudan; returns to Khartoum; agriculture in Gedaref, Kassala and River Nile.	Gold mining, livestock and informal trade.
Zain B2B fit	**Addressable now** INFERENCE	**Not addressable** for security, sanctions and reputational reasons INFERENCE

Network reality

- Before the war Sudan had four subsea cables and about 24,000 km of national fibre. Much of it is damaged, particularly in Khartoum, and operators moved core infrastructure and opened a new data centre in Port Sudan [29] VERIFIED.

- In August 2026 the humanitarian telecom service described connectivity in restored areas as "costly, congested and unstable" [35] VERIFIED.
- Government-ordered exam shutdowns ran for about 3.5 hours a day in April 2026 [40] VERIFIED. A third-party monitor logged a national blackout of about six and a half hours on 22 October 2026 [42] REPORTED. WhatsApp voice and video have been restricted since late July 2025 [34] VERIFIED.
- During the February 2024 nationwide outage, Zain reported restoring service in Port Sudan within about a day through a new switch covering Red Sea, Kassala, Gedaref, Northern and River Nile states, while Sudani and MTN were reported down for three days or more [16,45] REPORTED. Independent confirmation of the timing is limited, so Zain's own records should be the reference for any external claim.

> **Design principle that follows**
>
> Every enterprise offer should keep working when data is down: SMS and USSD fallback, store-and-forward devices, offline-tolerant apps and no reliance on WhatsApp calls INFERENCE.

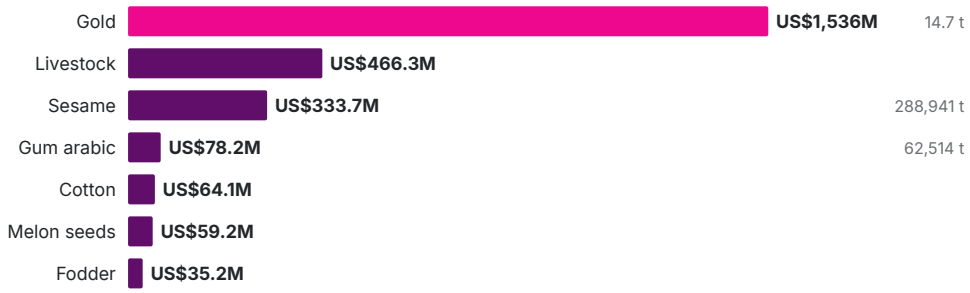
Who else is in the room

COMPETITOR	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS	IMPLICATION FOR ZAIN
Sudani (Sudatel, state-linked)	Business site offers voice and data, co-located hosting in two Tier III data centres, managed services, cloud connectivity, fibre and cabling, and satellite connectivity; EASSy and SAS-1/2 international capacity and over 25,000 km of terrestrial fibre [17] VERIFIED. FY2025 revenue US$341.8M (+29%); H1 2026 US$220.8M; still in "emergency mode" with Darfur and Kordofan sites out [18] VERIFIED. Its SAH wallet (with Africa Gulf Bank) had more than 867,000 customers by 30 Jun 2026 [18,12] VERIFIED.	Strongest on fixed, data-centre and satellite services, where Zain lists no offer. Likely to be favoured in some public tenders INFERENCE.
MTN Sudan	About 3.2M subscribers at end-2025, down from about 9M in 2022, roughly 22% share [11] REPORTED. FY2025 service revenue +288.1% in constant currency, EBITDA margin 34.7%; H1 2026 service revenue +156.0% [19] VERIFIED. MoMo wallet licensed 2022 [12] VERIFIED. A 2025 World Bank document called MTN "the only provider of mobile money services" supporting humanitarian operations [29] VERIFIED.	Incumbent in humanitarian mobile money; recovering fast and able to copy bundles. Its business offer pages were not reviewed UNKNOWN.
Starlink and VSAT	Not licensed in government-held Sudan [39,40] VERIFIED. Even so, Starlink was the second-largest ISP by traffic share (about 27%) in April 2026 and kept working through exam shutdowns [40] VERIFIED; another estimate puts it at about 23% of users [42] REPORTED. Humanitarian users must register kits and move to enterprise plans before the grace period ends in Nov 2026 [36] VERIFIED. The RSF-aligned authority claimed to authorise Starlink in June 2026 [40] REPORTED. TPRA issues VSAT authorisations [37] VERIFIED; licensed providers by name UNKNOWN.	A real substitute, but not one Zain can bundle. A partnership with a TPRA-licensed VSAT provider closes the gap legally INFERENCE.
Other wallets	Licensed e-money issuers include Bede (Zain), MoMo (MTN), SAH (Sudani), SudanPay, Cashi, Bravo, Zikher and Nil Pay [12] VERIFIED. Bank of Khartoum's Bankak had about 7M users and an 85% rise in activations after the war began [53] REPORTED.	Payment rails are crowded. Zain's edge is combining the wallet with SIM, messaging and connectivity in one account INFERENCE.

What businesses are buying now

- **Power independence.** Solar-panel imports rose about six-fold in the 12 months to June 2025 [31] VERIFIED; diesel generation costs about US$0.45/kWh against about US$0.02 from the grid [30] VERIFIED. Every remote site is now a solar site, and solar systems need monitoring INFERENCE.
- **Digital payments.** Cash shortages push customers to apps [22] REPORTED; eight wallets are licensed [12] VERIFIED.
- **Shared connectivity.** The humanitarian telecom service supported about 1,700 users at 70 locations (44 in Port Sudan, 21 in Kassala) in August 2026 [35] VERIFIED.
- **Satellite kits and internet cafés** in areas without networks, at US$2 to 6 per hour [39] REPORTED.
- **Government messaging and collection.** The Ministry of Finance signed an SMS deal with Zain for the Eisali e-collection system on 4 Oct 2026 [13] VERIFIED.
- **Cargo visibility.** Zain and Sudan Customs signed a smart-customs and IoT cargo supervision agreement with Jointech in Jan 2026 [14] VERIFIED.
- Volumes for dedicated links, VSAT and enterprise ICT overall UNKNOWN.

SUDAN OFFICIAL EXPORTS 2025 BY PRODUCT (PRELIMINARY)



Source: CBOS Foreign Trade Digest Q4 2025 [25] VERIFIED. Total official exports US$2.64bn. About 79% of gold output is reported not to pass through official exports [58] REPORTED.

03 · ZAIN TODAY

Zain's business portfolio and the gaps

What Zain Sudan Business already sells, what the numbers say about its position, and where the portfolio is thin compared with Zain's own Gulf operations.

Zain's position: the figures, by source and date

Different publications report different periods. They are listed separately so each can be checked against Zain Group's own filings before external use.

PERIOD	REVENUE	CUSTOMERS	OTHER	SOURCE	EVIDENCE
Q2 2025	US$133M (+87% YoY)	11.8M	Bede launched with Visa	Zain Group Q2 2025 earnings call [8]	VERIFIED
FY2025	US$661M (+92%)	12.3M	Net income US$290M	Zain Group releases via Zawya / Kuwait Times [9]; secondary summary [11]	REPORTED
Q1 2026	US$157M (+34% YoY)	12.4M (+13%)	EBITDA US$90M (58% margin); net income US$56M; data revenue +70%, 37% of revenue	Zain Group Q1 2026 release [7]	VERIFIED
Q1 2026			2,153 sites; more than 90% of network active in safe areas	Secondary summary of Zain reports [11]	REPORTED
Ownership	100% owned by Zain Group (Kuwait)			Zain Group SR2025 company overview [10]	VERIFIED
Business revenue split	Share of revenue from enterprise customers not published				UNKNOWN

For comparison, Sudani reported FY2025 revenue of US$341.8M [18] VERIFIED, about half of Zain's reported FY2025 figure. On every published measure Zain is the market leader, and it has the strongest recent relationship with government: an April 2026 meeting with the Telecom Minister in Khartoum on universal access, digital health and education, and an August 2026 ministerial visit to Zain Group in Kuwait on recovery and digital financial services [15,50] VERIFIED.

The published portfolio

Zain Sudan Business publishes a broad catalogue [1,3] VERIFIED. Tariffs for prepaid and hybrid lines are shown in SDG including VAT, with most effective from 15 June 2026; postpaid and enterprise products (APN, SMPP, postpaid Flex) are quoted on request.

FAMILY	WHAT IS PUBLISHED [3] VERIFIED	WHO IT SERVES BEST INFERENCE
Mobile & Flex	Prepaid, Postpaid and Hybrid voice and internet; Zain Business Flex packages from MICRO (1.5GB + 500 units) to MAX+ (100GB); Zain Hybrid, where each employee has a company bundle and personal use is not charged to the company	Every sector; staff SIM pools for NGOs, SMEs, contractors

Broadband	Prepaid, postpaid and hybrid data cards up to 1 TB; 4G routers and Wi-Fi devices (Huawei CPE and mobile Wi-Fi) bundled with data	Temporary offices, guesthouses, clinics, campuses
Enterprise connectivity	APN private access, with Zain's own listed use cases: HQ to branches, ATMs to bank data centre, POS, Civil Registry and electricity meters; POS connectivity bundles; VTS vehicle tracking; SMPP from 10,000 to 10 million SMS	Banks, government, utilities, logistics
Messaging & contact	Bulk SMS, Zain Aalin, Auto-Dialer; CCaaS (omnichannel contact centre), IVR, Short Code activation for all sectors	Banks (OTP), government, NGOs, health, retail
Cloud, ICT & IoT	ZainCloud; Blue Enterprise ERP ("centralized platform to streamline operations"); Fleet Management (provided by Bashasha, powered by Zain)	SMEs, logistics, government hosting
Fintech & self-care	Bede wallet (CBOS licence 2025/FIMP/4) [12] VERIFIED; postpaid bill payment through shops, wallets and banking apps including Bankak, Cashi, Bravo and Fawry; Bulk Recharge for corporate numbers; Zain SD app (zero-rated)	Employers, NGOs, SMEs, government collections
Channel	Authorized Sales Partner programme with partner map; roaming and international	SME volume through dealers

An under-sold asset: Bede for business

On the Business site, Bede is presented as a consumer wallet. Its own site, however, markets **Bede Corporate**: bulk fund distribution "for NGOs" and salary distribution from a spreadsheet upload [12] VERIFIED. Repositioning Bede as a collections, payroll and disbursement product for organisations, in the way Zain KSA sells Zain Collect [4] VERIFIED, is one of the fastest wins in this report INFERENCE.

Built, but not yet on the shelf

Zain Sudan's content system already holds product descriptions for several services that are not published as public pages [1] VERIFIED. Their commercial readiness is not known from outside UNKNOWN, but each matches a demand documented in this report:

PRODUCT (AS NAMED BY ZAIN)	WHAT IT IS	WHERE IT FITS
UCaaS (Cisco-based)	Unified communications as a service	Ministries and banks re-establishing offices in Khartoum
Push-to-Talk	Group voice over the mobile network	Logistics, NGO field teams, mining, construction
VSaaS	Video surveillance as a service	Warehouses, bank branches, compounds
Zdrop	Backup and disaster recovery	Any organisation that lost data in 2023 to 2024; banks, government
EDU-PRO / LMS-PRO, Zees	Education and learning-management systems	Universities returning to Khartoum with faculty abroad
Smart Agriculture ("Hagool")	Agriculture solution	Gedaref, Kassala and River Nile producers, cooperatives
Digital Ads; Call Signature	Targeted digital campaigns; branded caller identity	Retail, banks, SMEs

Publishing these is a low-effort way to widen the portfolio before any new build INFERENCE.

Gaps against Zain's own Gulf operations

Zain KSA, Kuwait and Bahrain sell enterprise services that Zain Sudan does not list. The comparison below is based on the peer business menus [4,5] VERIFIED and, for Bahrain, secondary sources because its site did not load [6] REPORTED. A dash means "not seen in the captured menu", not proof of absence.

CAPABILITY	ZAIN SUDAN	ZAIN KSA	ZAIN KUWAIT	ZAIN BAHRAIN
Dedicated internet access	Not listed	DIA	-	Dedicated Internet
IP-VPN / branch interconnect	APN only	IP-VPN	-	Local / global connectivity
Fixed wireless / 5G business broadband	4G data cards and routers	Zain AirFiber	5G internet; wireless fixed broadband	Wireless broadband
SIP trunk / fixed voice / PABX	Not listed	SIP trunk; SBCaaS	HCS	Landline & PABX
UCaaS / collaboration	Built, unpublished	Video conferencing	Teams, WebEx, Microsoft 365	UCaaS
SD-WAN / managed router	Not listed	SD-WAN; managed router	SD-WAN bundles	SD-WAN (Fortinet)
Managed security	Not listed	Anti-DDoS, FWaaS, SASE, WAF, managed SOC	MDR / SOCaaS	Managed security
Public / multi-cloud	ZainCloud (no detail)	Multi-cloud	Cloud computing	Cloud services
Data centre / co-location	Not listed	-	Zain Business Data Center	Co-location
Productivity SaaS (Microsoft 365, mail, e-sign)	ERP only	Mail, drive, digital signature, attendance	Microsoft 365	-
IoT beyond fleet (M2M SIM, fuel, CCTV)	Fleet, VTS, APN bundles	M2M, fuel automation, CCTV, signage	M2M	IoT; smart vehicle
AI and big data	Not listed	GPU-as-a-service; AI-enabled CCTV	-	Data & AI (ZainTECH)
Business payment collection	Bede (consumer-framed)	Zain Collect	-	-
Coverage map	Not listed	Connectivity map	-	-

Sudani, the local rival, already markets fibre, satellite connectivity, managed services and two Tier III data centres [17] VERIFIED, so the highlighted rows are where Zain is most exposed at home.

Priority gaps for Sudan INFERENCE

- **Enterprise connectivity:** DIA, IP-VPN and fixed wireless for banks, NGOs and oil operators. Zain's APN page already cites ATMs and Civil Registry.
- **SD-WAN with managed security**, starting as SD-WAN over 4G with VSAT failover.
- **Satellite** through a TPRA-licensed VSAT partner [37] VERIFIED.
- **Data centre and backup**: Zdrop plus partner co-location.

How to close them without new network build

INFERENCE

- Ask Zain Group and ZainTECH (active in KSA, Kuwait and Bahrain) whether peer products can extend to Sudan; ZainTECH coverage of Sudan UNKNOWN.
- Offer **dual-path resilience** (two APN routes plus data-card failover) as the interim answer to fixed-line gaps.
- Expose SMS, USSD and Bede through documented APIs, with Franco Pinto delivering client-side integration.
- Microsoft 365 or similar resale only after a sanctions and licensing check UNKNOWN.

04 · WHO TO SERVE FIRST

Sector by sector

Twelve sectors, ranked. Each chapter covers market state, buyer, pain, the Zain offer, why it works, why Zain, the approach, Franco Pinto's contribution and the flags.

The chapters that follow are ordered by the combined priority ranking explained in Section 5. Each one draws on the public evidence available in October 2026. Where a sector has no reliable public size figure, the chapter says so rather than estimating one. Entry offers are proposals for discussion with Zain's product and sales teams; specifications and pricing are Zain's to confirm.

RANK	SECTOR	LEAD BUNDLE	TIER
1	**NGOs, UN and humanitarian**	A beneficiary SMS/IVR line plus a Bede disbursement pilot for one agency.	Tier 1
2	**Banking and fintech**	An OTP SMPP pilot with one bank, and dual-path APN for one POS or ATM estate.	Tier 1
3	**Logistics, ports and transport**	A small fleet pilot plus automated delivery SMS for one transport operator.	Tier 2
4	**Retail and SMEs, including relocated businesses**	A Flex package with POS/QR acceptance, sold through Authorized Sales Partners.	Tier 2
5	**Government and public sector**	A notification short code for one more agency, modelled on Eisali.	Tier 2
6	**Health**	An SMS reminder pilot with one NGO health programme or private chain.	Tier 3
7	**Agriculture and exports**	A market-price SMS service with one cooperative or food-security programme.	Tier 3
8	**Mining and gold**	Tracking for a small vehicle fleet at one licensed operator.	Tier 4
9	**Education**	A campus data bundle plus exam-result SMS with one university.	Tier 4
10	**Oil and energy**	Generator and fuel monitoring at one site or installer.	Tier 4
11	**Construction and reconstruction**	Equipment trackers for one contractor on a Khartoum project.	Tier 4
12	**Hospitality**	Backhaul plus booking SMS for one hotel group.	Tier 4

Other opportunities outside the twelve

- **Diaspora remittances (B2B2C):** inbound remittance partners paying into Bede wallets. A partnership and licensing play for Zain Fintech; scored 3.65 / 5 in the strategy view (estimate) INFERENCE.
- **Diplomatic missions** relocating from Port Sudan to Khartoum need secure links [51] REPORTED.
- **Contact centres and media:** CCaaS, IVR and Auto-Dialer for outsourced service operations INFERENCE; media market size UNKNOWN.

RANK 1

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 1: MOVE NOW

NGOs, UN and humanitarian

Combined rank 1 of 12 Sales view rank 1 Strategy view rank 2 (score 4.30 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- 33.7M people in need; the 2026 plan needs US$2.87bn and is 14% funded; 170+ organisations operate [26] VERIFIED.
- The Emergency Telecommunications Cluster said in January 2026 it had **no 2026 funding** and moved its hubs to a cost-sharing, on-demand model [33] VERIFIED.
- TPRA ended Thuraya services from 1 Feb 2026 [33] VERIFIED. Humanitarian Starlink users must register kits and move to enterprise plans before the **grace period ends in November 2026** [36] VERIFIED.
- The shared humanitarian telecom service supported about 1,700 users at 70 locations in August 2026 [35] VERIFIED. Agencies (IOM, WFP, UNDP, UNICEF) are moving offices to Khartoum [51] REPORTED.

The buyer

ICT Manager, Logistics Coordinator and Country Operations Manager at UN agencies and INGOs such as WFP, IOM, UNICEF, International Medical Corps and NRC [36,35].

Their pain

- Connectivity budgets have moved from the cluster to each agency, while satellite options close.
- Reaching beneficiaries and confirming cash aid when data and calls fail.
- Fast staff connectivity in new Khartoum premises; an audit trail for donors.

What Zain offers

- **Bede Corporate** bulk disbursement and salary distribution, already marketed "for NGOs" [12] VERIFIED
- Bulk SMS, Short Code, IVR and Auto-Dialer for beneficiary feedback and accountability lines
- Staff SIM pools on Zain Hybrid or Business Flex; APN and data cards with failover for compounds and guesthouses
- Fleet Management for field vehicles; Push-to-Talk once published

Why it will work

Three facts land in the same quarter: the cluster's funding is gone, Thuraya is gone, and the Starlink grace period ends in November. Every agency must now buy licensed connectivity and messaging on its own budget, and Q4 2026 is the window. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Largest licensed operator (12.4M customers [7] VERIFIED), restored coverage in the SAF-held hubs where agencies operate, and SIMs, messaging and a licensed corporate wallet in one contract. Zain cannot cover Darfur and most of Kordofan, so it is the licensed backbone, with a satellite partner for the edges.

How to approach

"Reach beneficiaries by SMS and IVR, pay them through Bede, and keep your staff connected, even when data is down."

Entry offer: A beneficiary SMS/IVR line plus a Bede disbursement pilot for one agency. **Route:** Zain enterprise sales through ETC, Logistics Cluster and cash working-group forums.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Reconciliation and reporting portal for Bede disbursements, in Arabic and English
- Beneficiary registration with SMS and USSD fallback; IVR feedback lines
- Offline data sync and integration with agency beneficiary systems
- Fleet dashboards

Flags

- UN procurement is formal: tenders, vendor rosters, data-protection and neutrality rules.
- MTN's MoMo was described in 2025 as the only mobile-money provider supporting humanitarian operations [29] VERIFIED; Bede must displace an incumbent.
- Every payout needs sanctions and KYC screening; policies on serving each side's areas differ by agency.

RANK 2

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 1: MOVE NOW

Banking and fintech

Combined rank 2 of 12 Sales view rank 2 Strategy view rank 1 (score 4.30 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- The central bank restored the national payment switch in August 2026, connecting Omdurman National Bank first; Bank of Khartoum reopened Omdurman branches and a corporate branch; Omdurman National Bank reports 22 branches operating in Khartoum state [52] REPORTED.
- Eight e-money issuers are licensed: Bede (Zain, 2025/FIMP/4), MoMo (MTN, 2022/FIMP/1), SAH (Sudani with Africa Gulf Bank, 2025/FIMP/3, 867k+ customers by 30 Jun 2026), SudanPay, Cashi, Bravo, Zikher and Nil Pay [12,18] VERIFIED.
- Bankak (Bank of Khartoum) had about 7M users and an 85% rise in activations after the war began [53] REPORTED.
- The system is split: new banknotes are valid only in SAF-held areas, and the RSF side created a parallel central bank in Nyala in May 2026 [22] REPORTED.
- Number of operating banks and their IT budgets UNKNOWN.

The buyer

Head of Digital Channels, CIO and Head of Payments at banks; heads of operations at microfinance institutions and wallet operators.

Their pain

- The February 2024 blackout stopped payments [46] VERIFIED; continuity is now a board issue.
- OTP delivery for apps under heavy growth.
- ATM and POS uptime as branches reopen.
- Contact-centre load from returning customers.

What Zain offers

- SMPP, Bulk SMS and Short Code for OTP and transaction alerts
- APN private data for branches, ATMs and POS (a use case Zain already publishes), with a second path for failover
- IVR and CCaaS; ZainCloud; Zdrop backup once published
- Bede payouts and collections; Bill Payment; Bulk Recharge

Why it will work

Cash is scarce and the currency is collapsing, so digital money is now a necessity, and every bank and wallet is reconnecting to a restored national switch at the same time. Messaging and terminal links are what they need first. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Zain owns the SIM, the SMS rails and a licensed wallet, and already lists ATM-to-data-centre and POS links as APN use cases [3,12] VERIFIED. Bede's launch with Visa (Q2 2025) gives it a recognised payment partner [8] VERIFIED.

How to approach

"Transaction messaging and terminal connectivity that keep running through disruption."

Entry offer: An OTP SMPP pilot with one bank, and dual-path APN for one POS or ATM estate. **Route:** Zain key-account managers, with Franco Pinto in the technical workshops.

Franco Pinto value-add

- SMPP and API integration with core banking and wallet platforms
- Dual-path APN design for POS and ATMs
- Delivery-receipt and reconciliation dashboards
- IVR banking menus

Flags

- Bede competes with bank wallets, MoMo and SAH; keep connectivity and messaging offers neutral so rival wallets will still buy them.
- Central bank rules and KYC apply; screen bank ownership (Al Khaleej Bank is on Canada's Sudan sanctions list [65] VERIFIED).
- Multiple exchange rates distort pricing.

RANK 3

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 2: BUILD NEXT

Logistics, ports and transport

Combined rank 3 of 12 Sales view rank 3 Strategy view rank 5 (score 3.30 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- Port Sudan is "the principal conduit" of Sudan's foreign trade [25] VERIFIED.
- UNDP reports months-long import delays at Port Sudan and arbitrary state-level inland fees [27] REPORTED.
- In January 2026 Zain and Sudan Customs signed a strategic agreement with Jointech on smart customs and IoT cargo supervision [14] VERIFIED.
- The Logistics Cluster operates from Port Sudan and Khartoum; telecoms are working in Port Sudan, Kassala, Gedaref, Damazine and Kosti [36] VERIFIED.
- Port throughput: Sudan Ports Corporation publishes statistics, but figures were not extracted [60] UNKNOWN.

The buyer

Fleet Manager, Logistics Director and Operations IT at trucking firms, freight forwarders, exporters and port operators.

Their pain

- Route security and theft on the Port Sudan, Atbara and Khartoum corridors.
- Fuel control and driver accountability.
- Customers asking where their cargo is.
- Dispatch and customs paperwork in a congested port.

What Zain offers

- Fleet Management and VTS (Zain already publishes VTS data bundles)
- IoT and APN for yards and warehouses; VSaaS once published
- Bulk SMS delivery notices; CCaaS for dispatch
- Bede driver and fuel payouts

Why it will work

Almost everything that enters Sudan moves by truck from Port Sudan, and demand is shifting back to Khartoum. Visibility and control of that flow is a direct cost saving for operators. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Zain already sells fleet products, and the Customs/Jointech agreement puts Zain inside the cargo flow [14] VERIFIED. Coverage along the eastern corridor is likely its strongest INFERENCE.

How to approach

"Track every truck, and tell customers automatically."

Entry offer: A small fleet pilot plus automated delivery SMS for one transport operator. **Route:** Zain enterprise sales with Port Sudan operators and exporters.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Integration with transport-management systems
- Automated SMS notices and fuel/driver analytics
- Store-and-forward trackers for coverage gaps; satellite fallback units

Flags

- Complement the Jointech customs layer, do not compete with it.
- Ports Engineering Company Ltd, a Port Sudan state-owned firm, was designated by OFAC on 26 Jun 2026 [64] VERIFIED; screen every port and logistics counterparty.
- Road security and coverage gaps between towns.

RANK 4

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 2: BUILD NEXT

Retail and SMEs, including relocated businesses

Combined rank 4 of 12 Sales view rank 4 Strategy view rank 4 (score 3.70 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- Number of SMEs UNKNOWN: no census was found.
- Cash shortages push customers to apps, and SMEs stay open on solar [22,28] REPORTED. Solar-panel imports rose about six-fold in the year to June 2025 [31] VERIFIED.
- 14.9M internet users, 28.7% penetration [32] REPORTED; extreme poverty 59.7% [20] VERIFIED.
- Zain publishes prepaid Business Flex tiers from a daily MIN pack to MAX+ (100GB) [3] VERIFIED, and runs an Authorized Sales Partner channel [1] VERIFIED.
- Businesses are relocating to Port Sudan, the east and north, or returning to Khartoum INFERENCE.

The buyer

Owner or general manager; traders in Port Sudan, Kassala and Omdurman markets; Bankak and wallet merchants.

Their pain

- Getting paid without cash.
- Reaching customers after relocation.
- Affordable, predictable connectivity for a few staff.
- Stock and sales control.

What Zain offers

- "Business in a Box": Business Flex or Hybrid SIMs, Bede merchant QR and POS, Bulk SMS and Advertising Solutions
- Blue Enterprise ERP for growing firms
- Digital Ads and Call Signature once published

Why it will work

Small firms buy fast when the bundle is simple and sold by someone nearby. Zain's dealer network makes this a volume play rather than a direct-sales one. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Zain already publishes SME bundles, POS and a wallet, and has the largest retail channel. No competitor offers SIM, payments and marketing in one account at Zain's scale.

How to approach

"Get paid and reach your customers from one Zain account."

Entry offer: A Flex package with POS/QR acceptance, sold through Authorized Sales Partners. **Route:** Zain dealers and Authorized Sales Partners.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Lightweight POS and inventory app with an SMS marketing connector
- Automated Arabic WhatsApp text front desk (text only, since calls are restricted)
- Partner training kit for dealers

Flags

- Low ticket size and high churn.
- SDG prices lose value monthly.
- Avoid channel conflict with Zain's own sales and partners.

RANK 5

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 2: ZAIN-LED

Government and public sector

Combined rank 5 of 12 Sales view rank 12 Strategy view rank 3 (score 4.00 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- The government returned to Khartoum on 11 Jan 2026, and on 5 Mar 2026 the Cabinet stressed "digital transformation across all state institutions" [48] VERIFIED.
- Many ministries work from hosted premises (seven at the Sudanese Mineral Resources Co. headquarters in south Khartoum) and some still partly from Port Sudan; staff were told to report to Khartoum by end-October 2026 [49] REPORTED.
- On 4 Oct 2026 the Ministry of Finance signed an SMS agreement with Zain for the state **Eisali** e-collection system, signed for Zain by the head of its Business & Digital Services sector [13] VERIFIED.
- Government revenue is only 4.0% of GDP [20] VERIFIED, so collection systems are a priority INFERENCE. The state workforce was cut to about 40% early in the war [49] REPORTED.
- Procurement rules and budgets UNKNOWN.

The buyer

Ministry IT Directors and Digital Transformation Leads; state governments of Red Sea, Kassala, Gedaref, River Nile, Northern, White Nile and Khartoum.

Their pain

- Notifying citizens and collecting revenue reliably.
- Working from temporary premises with no fixed lines.
- Continuity of records and services after 2023 to 2024 losses.

What Zain offers

- The Eisali template: notification and e-collection short codes for tax, customs, passports and civil registry
- Citizen IVR and CCaaS; Bill Payment and Bede collection
- "Khartoum Return" office kit: data cards, APN, ZainCloud, UCaaS and Zdrop once published

Why it will work

A reference deal now exists with the Ministry of Finance, and every agency that collects fees faces the same problem. Replicating a proven model is faster than selling a new one. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Zain has the Eisali and Customs references [13,14] VERIFIED and documented ministerial engagement [15,50] VERIFIED. Sudani is state-linked and will compete for some tenders INFERENCE.

How to approach

"Reliable citizen notification and collection, live in weeks."

Entry offer: A notification short code for one more agency, modelled on Eisali. **Route:** Only through Zain's government-relations team; Franco Pinto supports in the background.

Franco Pinto value-add

- E-service portals with SMS and IVR integration
- Reconciliation of collections against agency ledgers
- Templates that make the next agency faster to launch

Flags

- Slow payment, in SDG.
- Designated persons sit in the SAF-aligned government [64,65] VERIFIED; no payment or benefit may reach a listed person. Counsel review required.
- Stay out of anything security-related; two rival authorities claim legitimacy.

RANK 6

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 3: PROGRAMME-LED

Health

Combined rank 6 of 12 Sales view rank 5 Strategy view rank 6 (score 3.30 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- The government says about 75% of health facilities had resumed operations by July 2026 [61] REPORTED.
- WHO reported 153 facilities or services suspended and 182 at reduced capacity across 13 states in August 2026 [61] REPORTED.
- The health cluster needs US$325.3M and is 3% funded [26] VERIFIED.
- Digital health was on the agenda of Zain's April 2026 meeting with the Telecom Minister [15] VERIFIED.

The buyer

Hospital Director, private hospital and pharmacy chain owners, NGO Health Programme Managers, Federal Ministry of Health.

Their pain

- Appointment and vaccination reminders.
- Cold chain on unreliable power.
- Stock-outs and disease-surveillance reporting.
- Paying community health workers.

What Zain offers

- Bulk SMS and IVR reminders; CCaaS for hotlines
- IoT and APN/data cards for facilities; ZainCloud
- Bede payments to health workers

Why it will work

Health programmes run on reminders, reporting and small payments, all of which Zain can deliver on any phone. Donor programmes fund much of this, so selling through NGO health partners is quickest. INFERENCE

Why Zain

National reach plus messaging, connectivity and payments in one operator, and existing ministerial interest in digital health.

How to approach

"Reminders and cold-chain alerts that work on any phone."
Entry offer: An SMS reminder pilot with one NGO health programme or private chain. **Route:** NGO health partners and private hospital groups.

Franco Pinto value-add

- IoT temperature loggers on solar
- Appointment system with SMS confirmations
- Privacy-aware hosting outside conflict zones

Flags

- Donor-dependent budgets.
- Sudan has no comprehensive data-protection law [70] REPORTED; health data needs contractual safeguards.

RANK 7

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 3: PROGRAMME-LED

Agriculture and exports

Combined rank 7 of 12 Sales view rank 6 Strategy view rank 7 (score 3.05 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- 2025 official exports (preliminary): livestock US$466.3M; sesame 288,941 t / US$333.7M; gum arabic 62,514 t / US$78.2M; cotton US$64.1M; melon seeds US$59.2M; fodder US$35.2M [25] VERIFIED.
- The Finance Minister said agricultural exports fell 43% and livestock exports 55% because Darfur and Kordofan are under RSF control [59] REPORTED.
- Gedaref, Kassala and River Nile remain the key government-side producing states INFERENCE; 2025 floods hit mostly Kassala and Gedaref (81% of about 120,000 people affected) [26] VERIFIED.
- Zain holds a written Smart Agriculture ("Hagool") product that is not yet published [1] VERIFIED.

The buyer

Agribusiness GMs, exporters of sesame and gum arabic, cooperative managers, and NGO and FAO food-security programmes. Named exporters {U}.

Their pain

- Getting market prices and advice to farmers.
- Running solar irrigation pumps reliably.
- Paying outgrowers and buying from farmers without cash.
- Trucking produce to Port Sudan.

What Zain offers

- Bulk SMS and IVR advisory; Smart Agriculture once published
- IoT for solar pumps; Fleet for export trucking
- Bede input-credit and buyer payments; Hybrid Flex for farm staff

Why it will work

Agriculture is the country's broadest economic base and its farmers already carry phones. Advisory and payments sold through programmes and exporters reach scale without one-to-one sales. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Zain's 12.4M-customer reach, a ready agriculture product in its system, and a wallet for cashless farmer payments.

How to approach

"One SMS line to every farmer."

Entry offer: A market-price SMS service with one cooperative or food-security programme. **Route:** Cooperatives, exporters' associations and NGO programmes.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Farmer registry with SMS advisory
- Soil and pump sensors
- Payout integration for exporters and programmes

Flags

- Seasonal demand and low ability to pay.
- Best sold through NGOs or FAO, so it overlaps with sector 1.

RANK 8

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 4: GATED

Mining and gold

Combined rank 8 of 12 Sales view rank 7 Strategy view rank 8 (score 3.00 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- The state miner SMRC reported 70 t of gold produced in 2025, 113% of target [57] REPORTED; official gold exports were 14.7 t worth US$1.536bn [25] VERIFIED.
- About 79% of output is reported not to pass through official exports; 2025 destinations were the UAE (56.3%) and Egypt (33.6%) [58] REPORTED.
- Mines in RSF-held South Darfur depend on Starlink cafés, with transfer fees rising from 17% to 23 to 25% [54] REPORTED.
- Named private operators on the government side UNKNOWN.

The buyer

Site Operations Manager, IT Lead and Security Manager at licensed mining companies; SMRC and the Ministry of Minerals.

Their pain

- Remote sites far from coverage.
- Tracking vehicles, equipment and output.
- Worker safety and payroll without cash.

What Zain offers

- IoT, Fleet, VTS, APN and data cards; Push-to-Talk once published
- Payroll through Bede
- Partner VSAT for sites beyond coverage (a portfolio gap)

Why it will work

Gold is Sudan's largest hard-currency earner and every site needs connectivity, tracking and payroll. INFERENCE

Why Zain

National presence and the only combined connectivity-plus-wallet offer for remote payroll.

How to approach

"Know where every vehicle and asset is."

Entry offer: Tracking for a small vehicle fleet at one licensed operator. **Route:** Zain account team, after Zain-led due diligence.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Geofencing, alerts and telemetry
- Store-and-forward devices
- ERP integration

Flags

- **High reputational and sanctions risk.** Gold is linked to armed-group financing, and targeted US designations can reach counterparties.
- Proceed only with Zain-led due diligence; exclude gold traders and anything in RSF-held areas.
- Conflict-minerals diligence required.

RANK
9

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 4: LATER

Education

Combined rank 9 of 12 Sales view rank 9 Strategy view rank 10 (score 2.95 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- Universities were ordered back to Khartoum campuses by August 2026; 71% of University of Khartoum academics remain abroad [62] REPORTED.
- The education cluster is 1.2% funded [26] VERIFIED.
- Exam-season shutdowns ran about 3.5 hours a day in April 2026 [40] VERIFIED.
- Zain holds written EDU-PRO / LMS-PRO and Zees education products, not yet published [1] VERIFIED. Sector size UNKNOWN.

The buyer

University ICT Directors, private school owners, Ministry of Higher Education.

Their pain

- Teaching with faculty abroad.
- Displaced students and remote learning.
- Fee collection and exam-result communication.

What Zain offers

- Data bundles, Business Flex and data cards for staff and students
- Bulk SMS for exam results; Bill Payment and Bede for fees
- EDU-PRO / LMS-PRO once published; ZainCloud

Why it will work

Universities must restart with a dispersed faculty, which makes connectivity and a learning platform a precondition, not an extra. INFERENCE

Why Zain

A ready education product in Zain's system plus bundles and payments.

How to approach

"Keep students connected and informed."

Entry offer: A campus data bundle plus exam-result SMS with one university. **Route:** University consortia and the Ministry of Higher Education.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Low-bandwidth learning platform
- Fee-payment integration
- Student SMS portal

Flags

- Very low budgets.
- Exam shutdowns disrupt service at peak demand.

RANK
10

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 4: LATER

Oil and energy

Combined rank 10 of 12 Sales view rank 8 Strategy view rank 11 (score 2.65 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- Heglig is reported pumping about 26,000 barrels a day, with the RSF extracting transit fees; exports, including South Sudan crude, run via the Bashayer terminal near Port Sudan [63] REPORTED.
- Solar is booming: imports up about six-fold in a year [31] VERIFIED; diesel power costs about US$0.45/kWh [30] VERIFIED.
- UNDP puts grid damage at up to US$3bn [28] REPORTED.

The buyer

Field IT Manager and HSE Manager at oil operators; solar importers and installers.

Their pain

- Telemetry from pipelines and remote assets.
- Crew safety.
- Generator fuel monitoring and theft.

What Zain offers

- Private APN and IoT for SCADA-type traffic
- Fleet for field crews; generator and fuel monitoring
- Solar-installer reseller channel for monitoring SIMs

Why it will work

Every generator and solar system is an asset worth monitoring, and installers are a ready channel. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Private APN and IoT in one operator, with national reach.

How to approach

"Secure private data links and remote monitoring."

Entry offer: Generator and fuel monitoring at one site or installer. **Route:** Zain key accounts; solar-installer partners.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Telemetry dashboards and alerting
- APN security design

Flags

- Assets sit in contested areas; long sales cycles.
- OFAC designated SBL Energy (India) on 26 Jun 2026 [64] VERIFIED; screen supply chains.
- Requires specialist security.

RANK 11

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 4: PREPARE NOW, SELL LATER

Construction and reconstruction

Combined rank 11 of 12 Sales view rank 11 Strategy view rank 9 (score 3.00 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- Rebuilding of power, water, roads, internet and sewage is under way in Khartoum, and ministries are rehabilitating buildings [48] VERIFIED.
- Grid damage alone is estimated at up to US$3bn [28] REPORTED.
- Reconstruction spend UNKNOWN: no public figure was found. Timing depends on peace and donor funding INFERENCE.

The buyer

Project Directors and Operations Managers at contractors; contractor associations.

Their pain

- Equipment tracking and theft.
- Site communications.
- Paying subcontractors and daily workers.

What Zain offers

- Fleet and IoT equipment tracking; Push-to-Talk once published
- Data cards and Hybrid Flex for site teams
- Workforce SMS and Bede payroll

Why it will work

Reconstruction will be large when funding arrives; contractors who are equipped early will choose Zain by default. INFERENCE

Why Zain

The full site kit (connectivity, tracking, payroll) from one operator.

How to approach

"Track equipment, connect sites, pay crews."
Entry offer: Equipment trackers for one contractor on a Khartoum project. **Route:** Contractor associations and donor-funded programmes.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Asset tracking
- Site reporting app
- ERP link

Flags

- Timing is uncertain.
- Contractors' ownership chains need sanctions screening.

RANK
12

SECTOR CHAPTER · TIER 4: WITHIN THE SME BUNDLE

Hospitality

Combined rank 12 of 12 Sales view rank 10 Strategy view rank 12 (score 2.65 / 5, estimate)

Market state

- Port Sudan hotels and guesthouses host UN, NGO and diplomatic staff; Khartoum guesthouses are served by humanitarian connectivity hubs [35] VERIFIED.
- Embassies are looking for premises in Khartoum [51] REPORTED. Sector size UNKNOWN.

The buyer

Hotel General Manager or IT Manager in Port Sudan, the east and Khartoum.

Their pain

- Guest Wi-Fi backhaul and failover.
- Bookings and confirmations from aid and business travellers.

What Zain offers

- Postpaid internet, data cards and routers, with APN failover
- POS and QR payments; CCaaS and booking SMS

Why it will work

International guests expect reliable internet, and guesthouses compete on it. INFERENCE

Why Zain

Restored coverage in the eastern hubs and a simple bundled offer.

How to approach

"Reliable guest internet."

Entry offer: Backhaul plus booking SMS for one hotel group. **Route:** Zain account managers; include in the SME bundle.

Franco Pinto value-add

- Wi-Fi management
- Booking engine with SMS confirmations

Flags

- Small and slow to recover; keep within the SME offer.

05 · WHERE THE OPENINGS ARE

Priority ranking

One combined ranking from two independent views of the market.

Two analyses ranked the sectors differently. The **sales view** ranked by urgency and access: how quickly a documented need can be met through an existing Zain product and a reachable buyer. The **strategy view** scored each sector on relative size (35%), speed to revenue (35%) and fit with Zain's brand (30%). Both are judgements, because no public figure exists for the size of Sudan's B2B telecom market UNKNOWN.

The combined ranking averages the two rank positions, with three adjustments: **NGOs/UN** lead banking on a tie because the November 2026 Starlink deadline makes timing decisive; **logistics** leads retail on a tie because Zain already sells fleet products and is inside the customs flow; and **government** moves up to fifth, despite the sales view placing it last on political risk, because the Ministry of Finance Eisali contract signed on 4 October 2026 is newer evidence that Zain can win and deliver there. Government is therefore a Zain-led track rather than a partner-led one INFERENCE.



Sectors ordered by combined rank. Bars: strategy weighted score (estimate). Circles: sales-view rank. Magenta: tier 1; plum: tier 2; grey: later tiers.

COMBINED	SECTOR	SALES RANK	STRATEGY RANK	STRATEGY SCORE	TIER
1	NGOs, UN and humanitarian	1	2	4.30	Tier 1: move now
2	Banking and fintech	2	1	4.30	Tier 1: move now
3	Logistics, ports and transport	3	5	3.30	Tier 2: build next
4	Retail and SMEs, including relocated businesses	4	4	3.70	Tier 2: build next
5	Government and public sector	12	3	4.00	Tier 2: Zain-led
6	Health	5	6	3.30	Tier 3: programme-led
7	Agriculture and exports	6	7	3.05	Tier 3: programme-led
8	Mining and gold	7	8	3.00	Tier 4: gated
9	Education	9	10	2.95	Tier 4: later
10	Oil and energy	8	11	2.65	Tier 4: later
11	Construction and reconstruction	11	9	3.00	Tier 4: prepare now, sell later
12	Hospitality	10	12	2.65	Tier 4: within the SME bundle

06 · WHAT WE RECOMMEND

Top offers and bundles

Five bundles built from products Zain already sells, plus one partnership that closes the largest gap.

#	BUNDLE	TARGET	ZAIN PRODUCTS INSIDE	WHY IT WINS
1	**Connected Aid**	NGOs, UN agencies	Bede Corporate disbursement; Bulk SMS, Short Code, IVR, Auto-Dialer; staff SIM pools (Hybrid/Flex); APN and data-card failover; Fleet	Funding shift, Thuraya exit and Starlink deadline land in Q4 2026 [33,36] VERIFIED. The wallet product already exists [12] VERIFIED.
2	**Transaction Messaging & Terminal Connectivity**	Banks, MFIs, wallets	SMPP OTP and alerts; dual-path APN for POS and ATMs; IVR and CCaaS; Bede payouts and collections	Banks are reconnecting to the restored switch [52] REPORTED; Zain already lists ATM and POS links [3] VERIFIED.
3	**Khartoum Return**	Ministries, agencies, banks, missions	Eisali-style notification and e-collection short codes; data cards and APN; ZainCloud; CCaaS; UCaaS and Zdrop once published	Reference contract with the Ministry of Finance [13] VERIFIED; institutions are moving into temporary premises [49] REPORTED.
4	**Export Corridor**	Trucking, exporters, port users	Fleet Management and VTS; IoT and APN; delivery SMS; Bede driver and fuel payouts	Port Sudan carries the country's trade [25] VERIFIED; customs IoT agreement [14] VERIFIED.
5	**Business in a Box**	SMEs, relocated firms, hotels	Business Flex or Hybrid SIMs; Bede merchant QR and POS; Bulk SMS and Advertising; Blue Enterprise ERP	Volume through Authorized Sales Partners; one account for connectivity, payments and marketing INFERENCE.
+	**Licensed satellite partnership**	NGOs, mining, remote sites	Partner VSAT sold under Zain, combined with SD-WAN over 4G	Closes the largest gap against Sudani [17] VERIFIED with a legal alternative to Starlink [37] VERIFIED.

Three portfolio moves that strengthen every bundle INFERENCE

- Reposition **Bede** as a business product (collections, payroll, disbursement), not only a consumer wallet.
- **Publish the products already written** (UCaaS, Push-to-Talk, VSaaS, Zdrop, education and agriculture systems).
- Add **enterprise connectivity** (DIA, IP-VPN, fixed wireless) and **SD-WAN with managed security**, drawing on Zain KSA, Kuwait and Bahrain offers and partners.

Every bundle is designed for disruption: SMS and USSD fallback, store-and-forward devices, offline-tolerant apps and no dependence on WhatsApp calls.

07 · WORKING TOGETHER

The Franco Pinto partnership model

Zain keeps the network, the licences and the customer. Franco Pinto builds the layer that turns Zain products into working solutions.

What Franco Pinto builds

- Integration and middleware: Bede, SMPP and USSD APIs connected to client ERPs, core banking and NGO beneficiary systems.
- Reconciliation and reporting portals for disbursements and collections.
- Automated Arabic and English messaging front desks and IVR flows.
- Fleet and IoT dashboards, alerts and analytics.
- Resilience design: offline-first apps, store-and-forward sync, SMS and USSD fallback, dual-path APN.
- Solution packaging, technical pre-sales support and partner training.

What stays with Zain

- Network, spectrum and licences.
- The wallet core and all regulated financial activity.
- The customer relationship, contract and brand.
- Government relations, led by Zain alone.
- Pricing to end customers.

Commercial structures for discussion

STRUCTURE	HOW IT WORKS
Setup and integration	A fee per enterprise client for integration work, milestone-based.
White-label licence	Franco Pinto software sold under the Zain brand, per client per period.
Managed service	Support, monitoring and outage runbooks on a retainer.
Performance share	A share of incremental Zain traffic (SMS, Bede transactions) that Franco Pinto solutions generate, with a clear attribution rule.
Engagement model	Referral, resale or delivery-only, to be chosen jointly per sector, with co-selling rules that avoid conflict with Zain's sales teams and Authorized Sales Partners.

Pricing

No prices are proposed in this report. Pricing, payment terms and the commercial model are to be agreed between Zain and Franco Pinto. Franco Pinto's preference is to contract with, and be paid by, a Zain Group entity outside Sudan, for the reasons set out in Section 9.

08 · THE ROAD AHEAD

90-day, 6-month and 12-month roadmap

Prove it, repeat it, scale it.

PHASE	ACTIONS	SECTORS	GO / NO-GO GATE
0 to 90 days Prove it	• Agree the partner framework, co-selling rules and engagement model. • Complete joint sanctions, KYC and data-protection reviews. • Zain nominates one pilot customer per tier-1 sector. • Build the Connected Aid demo: Bede disbursement reconciliation portal with SMS confirmations and an IVR feedback line, Arabic and English, offline-tolerant. • Reach agencies through ETC and Logistics Cluster forums before the November Starlink deadline. • Start a bank OTP SMPP pilot.	NGOs/UN; Banking; SME bundle design	Partner agreement signed and at least one pilot live
3 to 6 months Repeat it	• Turn pilots into reusable packages with standard onboarding. • Replicate the Eisali template for a second agency, led by Zain. • Launch Business in a Box through Authorized Sales Partners. • Start the Export Corridor fleet pilot. • Target 3 to 5 paying customers (a target, not a forecast).	Government; Logistics; Retail & SMEs	Repeat customers in at least two sectors
6 to 12 months Scale it	• Health and agriculture programmes through NGO partners. • Licensed VSAT partner and SD-WAN over 4G in market. • Publish written products (UCaaS, Push-to-Talk, VSaaS, Zdrop, education, agriculture). • Mining and oil only under Zain-led due diligence. • Reconstruction offer ready for when funding opens.	Health; Agriculture; Mining; Oil; Construction	Partner packages contributing measurable traffic

How success is measured

INDICATOR	WHAT IT SHOWS
Pilots live per sector	Speed from agreement to working service
SMS and API volume; Bede transaction value	Incremental Zain revenue from partner solutions
Fleet and IoT units connected	Adoption beyond messaging
Time to integrate a new client	Whether packages are truly repeatable

Timing that matters

November 2026: Starlink grace period ends for humanitarian users [36] VERIFIED. About 11 December 2026: the UN Darfur sanctions regime expires unless renewed again, after a two-month extension [67] VERIFIED. End of October 2026: ministry staff deadline to report to Khartoum [49] REPORTED.

09 · WHAT COULD GET IN THE WAY

Risks and safeguards

A summary for business readers. It is not legal advice.

RISK	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS	SAFEGUARD
Security	Darfur under RSF control since Oct 2025; Kordofan the conflict's epicentre; fighting in Blue Nile intensified from Aug 2026 [69] REPORTED. Canada advises against all travel to Sudan [68] VERIFIED.	Serve SAF-held areas only; Franco Pinto delivers remotely with no staff travel; host data outside conflict zones.
Outages and shutdowns	46 shutdowns since 2019, 10 in the last 12 months; daily exam shutdowns in April 2026 [40] VERIFIED; a national blackout of about 6.5 hours on 22 Oct 2026 [42] REPORTED.	Offline-tolerant design; no uptime SLAs that depend on Sudanese networks; carve-outs for state-ordered shutdowns.
Currency	Several rates: bank about 4,200, customs above 5,600, parallel about 10,000 SDG per US$ in Oct 2026 [23,24] VERIFIED REPORTED.	Indexed pricing where allowed; short cycles; prepaid setup; no SDG-denominated partner fees.
Sanctions	No country-wide embargo: broad US sanctions were revoked in 2017 and the terrorism designation rescinded in 2020. Targeted regimes remain: US E.O. 14098 and 13400 (with the 50% ownership rule), Canada's SEMA (Sudan) Regulations, EU Regulation 2023/2147 and the UN 1591 regime [64,65,66,67] VERIFIED. 2026 designations include RSF commanders and DIS/Giad-linked firms, among them a Port Sudan state-owned ports engineering company [64] VERIFIED.	Screen every customer, owner, bank and end user against UN, US, Canadian, EU and UK lists before contract and at each payment; exclude defence, security, DIS/Giad-linked, gold-trading and RSF-area end users; end-use declarations.
Payments outside Sudan	Repatriating hard currency from Sudan is slow and uncertain UNKNOWN; Sudan-based payers invite bank de-risking INFERENCE.	Contract and invoice through a Zain Group entity outside Sudan (for example Kuwait or Bahrain), paid from a named account in an agreed **non-USD currency** such as EUR, AED or KWD; US dollars only if counsel approves; no third-party payers.
Regulation	TPRA licenses VAS (SMS, IVR, USSD, payments, call centres) and VAS aggregators [37] VERIFIED. Whether a partner working through Zain needs its own licence UNKNOWN.	Operate under Zain's licences; confirm with TPRA through Zain.
Data protection	No comprehensive data-protection law; sectoral and cybercrime laws, with conflicting sources on which apply [70] REPORTED.	A data-processing agreement covering roles, security, transfers, breach notice, and lawful requests routed through Zain.
Export controls	Encryption and hardware may need classification before supply INFERENCE.	Classify each deliverable before shipment.
Competition	Sudani strong on fixed, data centre and satellite; MTN on humanitarian mobile money [17,29] VERIFIED.	Integration depth, references and bundled resilience as the moat.

Contract safeguards to include

- Mutual, continuing sanctions representations, with suspension and termination rights.
- KYC and ownership deliverables; re-screening at milestones.
- Approved payment currency and payer; sanctions-driven payment failure is not a default.
- Force majeure covering war, shutdowns, government action, FX controls and sanctions changes.
- Liability cap and exclusions.
- Governing law and arbitration seated outside Sudan (counsel to choose, for example English law with LCIA or DIFC).
- Anti-bribery and books-and-records clauses; no facilitation payments.
- Background IP retained; licence to deliverables on payment.

NEEDS COUNSEL

Before any contract, qualified counsel should confirm: which sanctions regimes apply to each party; the payment route and currency; whether a TPRA licence is needed for partner-delivered services; which data and cybercrime laws are in force; export-control classification; enforceability of foreign arbitration in Sudan; and a formal list screening of all Zain entities and officers with identifiers. A keyword screen of the official UN, US, Canadian, EU and UK lists (as published 16 to 25 Oct 2026) found no listing of Zain Sudan, Zain Group or its major shareholders; that is not a substitute for formal screening.

10 · NEXT STEPS

What we propose now

Six steps to move from this report to a first live pilot.

#	STEP	OUTCOME
1	**Leadership workshop** with Zain Sudan Business to confirm the sector focus and tiers	Agreed priorities and owners
2	**Product briefing** from Zain: specifications, SLAs, API access and status of unpublished products	Bundles built on confirmed specifications
3	**Partner framework**: engagement model, co-selling rules, commercial terms to be agreed	Signed framework
4	**Joint compliance review**: sanctions, KYC, data protection, payment route	Counsel sign-off
5	**Pilot nomination**: one NGO or UN agency and one bank, nominated by Zain	Two pilots scoped with KPIs
6	**Connected Aid demo** ready ahead of the November 2026 Starlink deadline	Live demonstration for agencies

Questions for Zain

- Can Zain confirm its FY2025 and Q1 2026 figures and share the enterprise revenue split for use in the final version?
- Which unpublished products (UCaaS, Push-to-Talk, VSaaS, Zdrop, EDU-PRO, Hagool) are ready to sell?
- Does ZainTECH or any Zain Group partner cover Sudan for SD-WAN, security, data centre or VSAT?
- Is a USSD and Bede API available to partners, and under which terms?
- Which Zain team owns humanitarian accounts and the ETC relationship?

How this report was prepared

Franco Pinto reviewed public sources only, published between 2024 and October 2026 and accessed on 26 October 2026, including World Bank, IMF, OCHA, central bank and regulator publications, operator filings, Zain Sudan's public business catalogue and the business menus of Zain KSA, Kuwait and Bahrain. No Zain systems, customer data or private information were used, and no Zain staff were contacted. Arabic sources were translated. Figures are reported as published; none have been estimated where a public figure was missing.

APPENDIX

Sources

All sources accessed on 26 October 2026 unless stated. [Arabic] marks Arabic-language sources.

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